the other faiths of which he knew into a new 'national faith'. It did not outlast his reign, but the attempt was extraordinary.

The concept of *sarva dharma sambhava*—accepting the equality of all religions—was propounded by great Hindu sages like Ramakrishna and Vivekananda, as we have seen, and upheld by Mahatma Gandhi and the Indian nationalist movement. While it was an axiomatic tenet of the post-Independence India in which I grew up, *sarva dharma sambhava* has been increasingly rejected by some proponents of Hindutva who spurn the notion of religious universalism in favour of a more robust assertion of Hindu cultural identity and Hindus' political rights. The Hindutva ideologue David Frawley (Pandit Vamadeva Shastri), for instance, warns against *sarva dharma sambhava*, arguing that only Hindus are asked to practise this belief, which simply leads to confusion and 'does not convince the opponents but deludes the Hindus themselves'. Frawley asks: 'When have Christians or Muslims in India ever been criticised for violating Sarva Dharma Samabhava?… Under the guise of religious tolerance this idea of equality of religions is used to prevent scrutiny of [others'] religious dogmas'.[1]

Yet the lived reality of Indian syncretism is difficult to deny. Hindus who made the arduous uphill trek to the cave temple of Amarnath in northern Kashmir, where an ice lingam, a naturally-formed stalactite, is worshipped, would have known that a third of their offerings went to the family of Adam Malik, a Muslim shepherd who, it was said, found the cave four centuries ago and led a Hindu *sadhu* to see the astonishing sight. In my novel, *Riot*, I wrote of Syed Salar Masud Ghazi, popularly known as Ghazi Miyan, a Muslim warrior who is worshipped as a saint by Hindus in the Bahraich area of Uttar Pradesh. A number of Muslim religious figures such as Nizamuddin Auliya, Moinuddin Chishti, Shah Madar and Shaikh Nasiruddin (alias Chiragh-i-Dilli) are also worshipped by Hindu devotees to this day. Even the richest Hindu temple, at Tirupati, has a Muslim connection. One legend has it that Lord Balaji's second wife is Muslim, Bibi Nanchira, the daughter of a sultan who was enamoured of the Lord, much to her father's dismay, until Balaji appeared in the Sultan's dreams and informed him that He wished to marry his daughter. The Sultan, overwhelmed, acquiesced and today